most probably by way of the Horn of Africa at a time when the oceans were significantly lower and the coastal corridors much wider than today as a consequence of ice age glaciation. Their female descendants subsequently mutated to form two major lines, one carrying Haplogroup N, the other carrying Haplogroup M.

These two haplogroups N and M together define the ‘Out of Africa’ thesis. This argues that the female ancestors of those modern humans carrying Haplogroup M kept on moving eastward, supplanting and replacing (and to some degree interbreeding with) earlier humanoid species as they spread. Their descendants are now spread across most of the globe – but not in Western Eurasia in any significant numbers. Some 60 per cent of the modern inhabitants of the Indian subcontinent carry Haplogroup M, with the heaviest concentrations in the south, the east and along the west coast.

Meanwhile, the carriers of Haplogroup N had spread along the eastern shores of the Mediterranean and the southern fringes of the Black Sea and the Caspian Sea. Only in comparatively recent times did they move into Western and Northern Europe, where they remain the predominant haplogroup. But like all haplogroups, this Haplogroup N mutated and further divided into a number of lesser haplogroups, one of which is Haplogroup R – which is found in the remaining 40 per cent of South Asians.

How long ago these human migrations first began is disputed, but there is general agreement that our ancestors were preceded out of Africa by at least three species closely related to ourselves, including the Neanderthals and Denisovans. This is where Hardy’s Aquatic Ape hypothesis comes in, since these watery humanoids were exceptionally well placed to take advantage of those phases during the Late Pleistocene epoch, which ended some 12,000 years ago, when glaciation lowered ocean levels and exposed wider shorelines. These provided a natural corridor for